CINEMA ▼

INDIA IN FOCUS

A range of independent Indian cinema is being showcased at this year's **Busan International Film Festival**

Busan International Film Festival has transformed into a consistent showcase for the diversity and depth of Asian cinema. This year, the festival runs from October 6 to 15, boasting a selection of distinct Indian voices. From emerging filmmakers to established auteurs, these films underline the ambition of Indian independent filmmaking landscape. *Our picks of the Indian films at the festival:*

1. Not a Hero
Rima Das returns to Busan with an Assamese coming-of-age drama about 11-year-old Mivan, whose move from the city to rural Assam unsettles both him and the conservative village. Das is probably the only contemporary Indian filmmaker with such a keen eye for the contours of young adolescence.



2. Lovers in the Blue Night
Fresh from its world premiere at Venice International Film Festival where it was crowned Best Asian Film, Anuparna Roy's sophomore Hindi film follows four people negotiating migration, desire and loneliness in Mumbai. That her second film comes just a year after her debut and her Best Director win at Venice is no mean feat.

3. Selvi
Sailesh Rathnakumar's feature debut follows a young home-care worker whose already punishing shifts multiply after a personal tragedy.

4. Khoriya
Vishwendra Singh's feature debut follows two Nepali half-brothers whose poultry business is upended by a bird flu outbreak. Shot in Nepali and Hindi, *Khoriya* has Ashim Ahluwalia as executive producer.

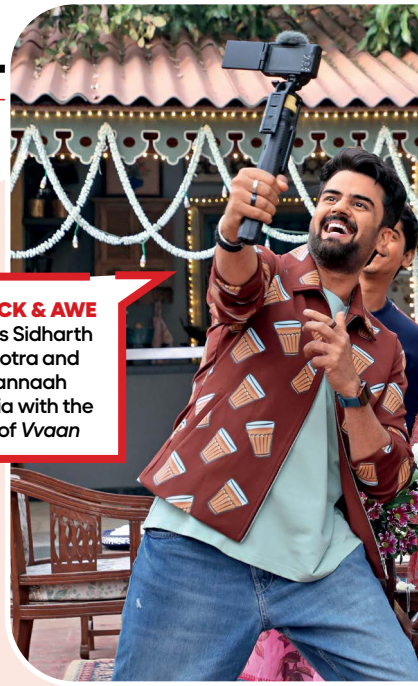
5. Salt Electric
Set in Goa, Paromita Dhara's short film follows an 18-year-old as she navigates the uneasy passage into adulthood and desire after discovering an adult videotape at home. The Konkani film is also the only Indian short film on the lineup. ■

—Poulomi Das





LOUD AND CLEAR Stills from (clockwise from top) *Khoriya*, *Selvi* and *Lovers in the Blue Light*



SHOCK & AWE Leads Sidharth Malhotra and Tamannaah Bhatia with the cast of *Vvaan*

FILM ▼

Horror in

WITH ***THE VVAAN – FORCE OF THE FORREST***, TVF VENTURES INTO FOLKLORE, AND BRINGS A STORY ROOTED IN INDIAN LEGEND TO CINEMAS

For long, watching a title from The Viral Fever (TVF) banner meant seeing stories of the aspirations of the Indian middle class or youth (*Permanent Roommates*, *Kota Factory*, *Panchayat*) first on YouTube and then on streaming. That well-etched image is set aside for The *Vvaan – Force of the Forrest*, a folklore-based action film starring Sidharth Malhotra and Tamannaah Bhatia. For Arunabh Kumar, co-founder of TVF and writer of *Vvaan*, heading to cinemas has been a dream that materialised thanks to co-producer Ekta Kapoor. Both have bonded "during temple runs for festivals" and both felt there was a need for stories rooted in Indian gods and legends.

"Every religious site has

FROM THE GROUND UP ▶ *Vvaan* director Deepak Kumar Mishra and writer Arunabh Kumar